

Conception The fertilization of the ripened egg by the sperm and its implantation in the uterine wall.

Contractions The regular tightening of the uterine muscles in labor as they work to dilate the cervix and press the baby down the birth canal.

Cordocentesis Fetal blood sampling or umbilical vein sampling. A diagnostic test to detect fetal abnormalities.

Crowning The moment when the baby's head appears at the entrance of the vagina during labor and does not slip back again.

Cystitis Infection of the bladder.

Diabetes Failure to metabolize glucose, indicated by excess sugar in blood and urine.

Dilation The progressive opening of the cervix caused by uterine contractions during labor.

Dizygotic See *Twins*.

Doppler A method of using ultrasound vibrations to listen to the fetal heart.

Doula A paid helper who provides support before, during, and after childbirth.

Ectopic pregnancy A pregnancy that develops outside the uterus.

Edema Swelling caused by water retention and blood pooling in the lower body. In rare cases this can be a sign of preeclampsia.

EDD The estimated date of delivery.

Electroencephalogram (EEG) A test where electrodes are placed on the scalp to record the electrical activity of the brain.

Embryo The earliest form of the baby in the uterus, from 4 weeks of pregnancy until around 10 weeks of pregnancy, after which it is termed a fetus.

Endometrium The lining of the uterus.

Engaged When the baby descends into the pelvis and three-fifths of his head have moved below pelvic bone. Usually a sign that labor is imminent.

Engorgement Congestion of the breasts with milk. If long periods are left between feedings, or the baby is not latched on well, painful engorgement can occur. This can be relieved by putting the baby to the breast or expressing the excess milk.

Epidural anesthesia A method of numbing the nerves of the lower spinal cord to ensure pain-free labor.

Episiotomy A surgical cut in the perineum to enlarge the entrance to the vagina.

Estrogen Hormone, levels of which rise rapidly in the first weeks of pregnancy, thickening the lining of the uterus, swelling breasts, and keeping hair and nails in a growth phase.

External cephalic version (ECV) The manipulation of the fetus by gentle pressure into the cephalic (head down) position. This may be done by an obstetrician or midwife at the end of pregnancy if the baby is in a breech or transverse position.

Fallopian tubes Two tubular structures (one on each side of the uterus) leading from the ovaries to the uterus.

Fertilization The meeting of the sperm with the egg to form a new life. See also *Conception*.

Fetus The developing baby in the uterus, known by this name around 10 weeks of pregnancy until birth.

Fibroids A benign (noncancerous) growth of muscle in the uterus, usually spherically shaped.

Flavonoids A group of compounds with antioxidant properties (also known as bioflavonoids).

Fontanelle The soft spot on top of a baby's head, which closes after about one and a half year's of age.

Forceps A tonglike instrument that fits on either side of the baby's head and is used to help deliver the baby.

Fundal height The distance from the pubis to the top of the uterus. It's measured

regularly throughout pregnancy and is used as a marker of fetal growth.

Fundus The top of the uterus.

Hepatitis Viruses (named A, B, C, E, and others) that infect the liver, causing jaundice and generalized illness.

Hormone A chemical messenger in the blood that stimulates various organs to carry out specific actions.

Human chorionic gonadotrophin (hCG) A hormone released into the woman's bloodstream by the developing blastocyst after implantation. Its presence in the urine means that she is pregnant.

Hypnobirthing A type of self-hypnosis using visualization and breathing techniques to achieve a deep state of relaxation during labor.

Hyperemesis gravidarum Unrelenting, excessive nausea and vomiting preventing intake of adequate amounts of food and fluids. It can lead to dehydration.

Hypertension High blood pressure. During pregnancy this can reduce the fetal blood supply.

Hypotension Low blood pressure.

Implantation The embedding of the fertilized egg within the wall of the uterus.

Induction The process of artificially starting labor and keeping it going.

Intravenous (IV) The infusion of fluids directly into the bloodstream by means of a fine catheter introduced into a vein.

In vitro fertilization (IVF) A type of assisted conception where fertilization occurs outside the body and embryos are transferred back into the uterus.

Jaundice, neonatal The yellow color noticed in the eyes and skin due to an increased level of bilirubin (a substance produced when the liver breaks down red blood cells).